

From Erving to Goffman

A Work in Performance?

by Yves Winkin

Erving Goffman was among the most prominent sociologists of the twentieth century. An unmatched observer of everyday human interaction, he has only grown in influence since his untimely death in 1980. Yet, sustained biographical accounts of Goffman remain sparse.

Translated from the French (*D'Erving à Goffman: Une œuvre performée?*, 2022, MkF éditions), this biography by Yves Winkin—one of the world's leading Goffman scholars—is an elegantly written and deeply informed account of the sociologist's life. *From Erving to Goffman* offers a reading of Goffman through his performances on stage, at the lectern, before an audience. Winkin treats the lecture—Goffman's own conference talks and writings on the lecture form—as a reflexive device to draw out how the Canadian-born Erving became Goffman the American sociologist.

From Erving to Goffman is a biography in miniature, joining an account of the scholar's life with a collection of conference vignettes from his travels. It is a story of a sociologist made in performance, with photographers banned and appearances—on and off-stage—orchestrated. *From Erving to Goffman*, the latest installment in the Goffman in the Open series, is an unusually perceptive portrait-in-fragments of the sociologist who became Goffman.

Yves Winkin was trained in Communication at the University of Liège (Belgium) and at the University of Pennsylvania. He has taught in Belgium, France, and elsewhere in the world, from Africa to China. He has written extensively on the history of recent American social sciences with a focus on the life and work of Erving Goffman, whom he got to know from 1976 to 1982. Thanks to Goffman, he spent a semester observing monkeys at the Philadelphia zoo.

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Goffman in the Open Series